Bae Omerah Hafidah Dianalan-Lucman

Bae Omerah Hafidah D. Dianalan-Lucman (also rendered as *Bai Omera* or *Bai Omeira Dimakuta Dianalan-Lucman*) is a Maranao noblewoman, career public servant, and institutional pioneer who served as the inaugural Secretary and Chief Executive Officer of the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF) from 2010 to 2012, making her the first woman to hold the cabinet-level position overseeing the rights and welfare of Muslim Filipinos.<ref name="ncmf_southluzon">National Commission on Muslim Filipinos South Luzon Office. "About Us." NCMF-Southluzon.weebly.com. Retrieved 2024.</ref>

Born into one of Lanao del Sur's most storied political dynasties, she grew up watching her father, Sultan Atty. Omar Maruhom Dianalan, govern Marawi City for nearly two decades, negotiate the tensions between Islamic tradition and Philippine statehood, and sponsor legislation that shaped the province for generations.

That upbringing became her template. Over a career spanning provincial governance, social welfare, cooperative economics, and executive administration, Dianalan-Lucman wove together the twin threads of her identity: the daughter of a sultan who understood that public service is an act of faith, and a Filipino technocrat who knew that institutions matter just as much as intentions.

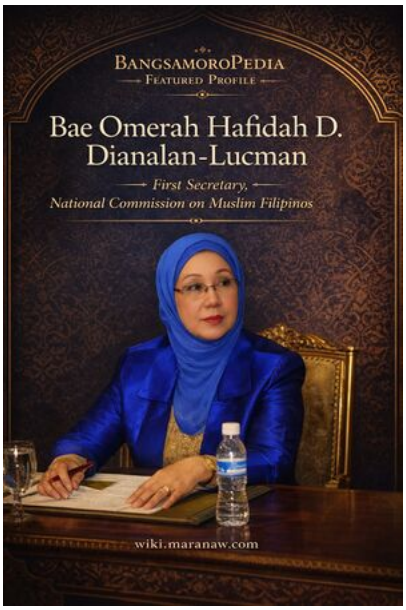
Her most enduring contribution was the transformation of the 23-year-old Office on Muslim Affairs (OMA) into a fully empowered, cabinet-level commission under Republic Act No. 9997.<ref name="ra9997">Republic Act No. 9997, "National Commission on Muslim Filipinos Act of 2009," signed into law by President Gloria Macapagal-Arroyo on February 18, 2010.</ref>

The organizational bedrock she built during her two years at the NCMF, including its functional bureaus, its operational manuals, and its reconceived mandate as a policy body rather than a pilgrimage office, remains the structural foundation of the Commission to this day.

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Bae Omerah Hafidah D. Dianalan-Lucman



Born	Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Religion	Islam
Title	Bae (Maranao noblewoman); Secretary and Chief Executive Officer, National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
Spouse	Dr. Alibasher Lucman (deceased; former OMA Executive Director, 1990–1992)
Father	Sultan Atty. Omar Maruhom Dianalan
Mother	Bae Dimakuta, daughter of Governor Datu Hadji Alawi Mandangan Dimakuta
Political party	Non-partisan (government appointee)
Known for	First Secretary/CEO of the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (2010–2012); institutional founding of the NCMF from the former Office on Muslim Affairs

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Early Life and Lineage

Bae Omerah grew up in Marawi City, the capital of Lanao del Sur and the only predominantly Muslim chartered city in the Philippines. She was born into the Dianalan clan, one of the prominent royal clans of Ranao, whose bloodlines run through the Sultanate of Guimba, one of the five united sultanates that historically governed Marawi.<ref name="bangsa_sultan">Bangsa Ranao Blog. "Sultan Atty. Omar Maruhom Dianalan." bangsaranao.blogspot.com. May 2013.</ref>

Her father, Sultan Atty. Omar Maruhom Dianalan (1931–1990), was a lawyer, a passionate advocate for the Maranao people, and a man described by those who knew him as a servant-leader who died without much wealth after nearly two decades as Mayor of Marawi City.<ref name="bangsa_sultan" /> He was also elected Assemblyman and then Congressman of Lanao del Sur, representing the province's first district, and he served as a member of the Board of Regents of Mindanao State University.<ref name="bangsa_sultan" />

Among his most visible legacies was the renaming of Marawi City as the "Islamic City of Marawi," formalized through City Council Resolution No. 19-A on April 15, 1980, during his mayoral tenure.<ref name="marawi_wiki">Wikipedia. "Marawi." en.wikipedia.org. Accessed 2024.</ref>

Her mother was the daughter of the late Lanao Governor Datu Hadji Alawi Mandangan Dimakuta of Watu, which is why Bae Omerah carries the matronymic middle name "Dimakuta" in many official records, a sign of the dual royal lineage she inherited from both sides of her family.<ref name="bangsa_sultan" />

The family home in Marawi was not simply a household. It was a meeting place for sultans, ulama, and politicians, and growing up inside it gave Bae Omerah an unusually clear view of how traditional authority and modern governance can either work together or tear each other apart.

In the Maranao culture, the title of **Bae** is given to women of noble rank, roughly equivalent to a princess or queen in the context of the Ranao sultanates. For Bae Omerah, the title was never ceremonial. It carried an expectation of service, and the community's understanding of her career was filtered through that expectation from the beginning.

She married Dr. Alibasher Lucman, a government official who served as Executive Director of the Office on Muslim Affairs (OMA) from 1990 to 1992.<ref name="moroherald">Moro Herald. "New National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF) Replaces Office on Muslim Affairs (OMA)." moroherald.com. April 22, 2010.</ref> Their marriage brought together two of the most influential families in Lanao, the Dianalan clan of Marawi's Guimba Sultanate and the Lucman clan, whose own political and intellectual contributions to the Bangsamoro community span several generations.

Education

Specific details of Dianalan-Lucman's formal educational credentials remain incompletely documented in publicly available archives. Based on her career trajectory through legal and policy-intensive government positions, including service at the Department of Social Welfare and Development (DSWD) at the undersecretary level, researchers may consult the records of the National Library of the Philippines and the Civil Service Commission for primary documentation of her academic background.

What is clear from her public record is that her professional formation was shaped as much by lived political experience as by formal schooling. Growing up as the daughter of a lawyer-sultan who governed a city in one of the Philippines' most politically complex provinces gave her a working knowledge of governance, Islamic jurisprudence, and community negotiation that no classroom alone could have provided.

Career

Provincial Government and DSWD

Before her appointment to the cabinet, Bae Omerah served as Vice Governor of Lanao del Sur, giving her direct experience in managing provincial governance under the pressures that define politics in Muslim Mindanao.<ref name="bangsa_sultan" />

She later moved into national service, serving as an Undersecretary of the Department of Social Welfare and Development (DSWD), where she worked on poverty alleviation and community welfare programs with particular relevance to Muslim Filipino communities.<ref name="moroherald" />

Cooperative Development Authority

From her work at DSWD, Dianalan-Lucman transitioned to lead the Cooperative Development Authority (CDA), where she served as Administrator and Chairperson for five years.<ref name="moroherald" />

At the CDA, she became a committed advocate for the cooperative movement as a tool for economic empowerment in Muslim Mindanao. Her core argument was straightforward: you cannot build a lasting peace in a community where people have no economic stake in the outcome. Financial literacy and access to capital, in her view, were prerequisites for political stability, not luxuries to be addressed after the security situation improved.

Her years at the CDA also gave her a practical command of Islamic microfinance principles, particularly the concept of Riba-free (interest-free) credit that aligns with Shari'ah law, a framework she would later formalize as NCMF Secretary through the Bureau of Muslim Economic Affairs.

She also carried her advocacy into environmental and civil society spaces during this period. As president of the Provincial Multi-sectoral Women's Council (PMWC), she championed the protection of Lake Lanao, calling for a coalition of stakeholders from government, the private sector, and traditional community leaders to halt the environmental degradation of the lake that is central to Maranao identity.<ref name="mgpnews">MAGKAISA tungo sa GANAP na PAG-UNLAD News. "Lake Lanao Stakeholders' Conference." mgpnews2016.blogspot.com. 2006.</ref>

The NCMF Appointment (2010)

On February 18, 2010, President Gloria Macapagal-Arroyo signed Republic Act No. 9997, the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos Act of 2009, abolishing the 23-year-old Office on Muslim Affairs and replacing it with a full-fledged commission with expanded powers.<ref name="ra9997" /> The law took effect on March 6, 2010.

Bae Omerah took her oath of office on March 10, 2010, one day before the constitutional ban on appointments took effect ahead of the May 10 national elections.<ref name="ca_decision">Philstar.com. "CA Affirms Dismissal of 5 GMA Midnight Appointees." philstar.com. September 1, 2012.</ref>

President Arroyo officially designated her as the pioneer Secretary and Chief Executive Officer of the NCMF, making her the first woman to lead the Philippines' primary government body for Muslim affairs.<ref name="ncmf_southluzon" /><ref name="moroherald" />

The commission she inherited was brand new in name but burdened with the institutional inertia of the agency it replaced. Her first task was not policy, but architecture: drafting the organizational structure, establishing the functional bureaus, and defining what it actually meant for the NCMF to be a "policy body" rather than a logistical office that mainly processed Hajj applications.

Tenure as NCMF Secretary (2010–2012)

Building the Institution

Dianalan-Lucman's two years at the NCMF were defined by a determined effort to expand what the agency thought it was allowed to do. The OMA had largely defined itself around the annual Hajj pilgrimage and occasional cultural events. She insisted that the NCMF's mandate under RA 9997 was far broader, and she moved quickly to build the internal structures that could carry that mandate.

She established functional bureaus covering External Relations, Muslim Economic Affairs, and Legal Affairs, ensuring that the NCMF could advise the President of the Philippines on matters ranging from international Islamic diplomacy to the enforcement of Muslim Personal Laws in regions outside the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM).<ref name="ncmf_wiki">Wikipedia. "National Commission on Muslim Filipinos." en.wikipedia.org. Accessed 2024.</ref>

The Organizational Structure and Manual of Operations she developed during this period became the administrative template that successive NCMF leaderships have built upon.<ref name="ncmf_southluzon" />

Hajj Reforms

One of her first major executive actions as Secretary was a total audit of the pilgrimage administration. The OMA's Hajj operations had long been plagued by "ghost pilgrims," hidden fees, and unaccredited travel agencies exploiting the process.

Dianalan-Lucman implemented stricter accreditation requirements for travel agencies and medical service providers. She also worked to reduce the dependence on middlemen who extracted fees without providing legitimate services to pilgrims.

She actively engaged with Muslim communities across the country, launching a nationwide consultation and dialogue with pilgrims and local communities to understand their concerns firsthand.<ref name="phifocy">Philippine Foreign Policy (PHIFOCY) Blog. "Philippines/Islam: NCMF Consulting Moro Communities Nationwide." phifocy-lavariaskarlao.blogspot.com. 2010.</ref>

She also recommended to Malacañang the official date of Eid'l Fitr as a national holiday, and formally requested an Eid'l Fitr reception at Malacañang Palace from President Benigno Aquino III, reinforcing the symbolic visibility of Muslim Filipinos within the national government.<ref name="abna">ABNA News Agency. "Eid'l Fitr in Philippines on Sept. 10." en.abna24.com. August 30, 2010.</ref>

Madrasah Education and Shari'ah

Dianalan-Lucman directed the NCMF to collaborate with the Department of Education (DepEd) to standardize the Arabic Language and Islamic Values Education (ALIVE) program, pushing for the formal integration of Madrasah education into the national curriculum rather than its treatment as a peripheral or informal track.

She was also a vocal advocate for strengthening the Shari'ah court system in the Philippines, particularly in areas outside the BARMM where Muslim Filipinos live in significant numbers but have limited access to Shari'ah adjudication.

She initiated a formal review of the Code of Muslim Personal Laws (Presidential Decree No. 1083) to identify implementation gaps in the Shari'ah court system, arguing that legal reform had to accompany institutional reform if the NCMF was to genuinely protect the rights of Muslim Filipinos.

Islamic Microfinance

Drawing directly from her years at the CDA, she directed the NCMF's Bureau of Muslim Economic Affairs to promote Islamic microfinance, specifically Riba-free credit facilities for small Muslim-owned businesses. The goal was to give Muslim entrepreneurs access to capital without forcing them to choose between economic survival and religious compliance with the prohibition on interest-bearing loans.

Interreligious Outreach

Her NCMF also extended its reach beyond internal Muslim affairs. She commended the cooperation of local government units from predominantly Christian areas, such as Compostela Valley, that hosted the 38th Regional Qur'an Reading Competition for Region XI, using the event as a model for interreligious goodwill and cultural understanding.<ref name="oma_davao">National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (OMA Davao Blog). "Regional Qur'an Reading Competition." omadavao.blogspot.com. Accessed 2024.</ref>

Challenges and Controversies

The Midnight Appointment Dispute

The transition from the Arroyo to the Aquino administration in 2010 placed Dianalan-Lucman at the center of a politically charged constitutional dispute.

Shortly after President Benigno Aquino III assumed office, his administration issued Executive Order No. 2, which sought to revoke the appointments of nearly a thousand "midnight appointees" made by the Arroyo government in the months before the May 2010 elections.

Dianalan-Lucman was among the appointees targeted. She fought back, filing a petition before the Supreme Court of the Philippines, arguing that EO No. 2 unconstitutionally expanded the definition of a midnight appointment and effectively amended a provision of law through executive action.<ref name="gma_news">GMA News Online. "Aquino Hits SC Decision on 'Midnight Appointee.'" gmanetwork.com. October 14, 2010.</ref>

> "[Executive Order No. 2] unduly expands the constitutional definition of appointments and must be stricken down as void for over-breadth. In one fell swoop, through the mere issuance of EO 2, Malacañang has cut down the term of the NCMF secretary, amending through executive action a provision of the law which only Congress could lawfully amend."

The Supreme Court agreed with her preliminary arguments, issuing a status quo ante order that temporarily prevented the Aquino administration from removing her from office.<ref name="gma_news" /> The case eventually moved to the Court of Appeals, which remanded the factual issues from the Supreme Court.

In its ruling, the Court of Appeals held that Dianalan-Lucman was not a midnight appointee. The CA found that she took her oath of office on March 10, 2010, one day before the constitutional ban on appointments took effect on March 11, and that her right to enter the position was "plenary and complete" from the moment she was sworn in.<ref name="ca_decision" />

The Aquino administration also argued, separately, that she was disqualified from leading the NCMF because, as a woman, she could not serve as leader of the Hajj mission according to Islamic tradition. The Court of Appeals rejected this argument, citing a sworn affidavit from Islamic law expert Aleem Said Ahmad Basher, who explained that leading the Hajj mission is "more of a social, ceremonial or diplomatic function" and that a woman is fully qualified to serve in that capacity.<ref name="ca_decision" />

Despite the favorable rulings, the political climate made her continued tenure untenable. She eventually accepted the transition, turning over the agency in April 2012 to incoming Secretary Mehol K. Sadain.<ref name="ncmf_southluzon" /><ref name="oma_davao" />

She remained as a Commissioner of the NCMF for the remainder of her four-year commission term, ending in 2014.

Personal Values and Leadership Style

Those who worked alongside Dianalan-Lucman consistently describe a leader who governed by consensus rather than decree. Her approach to policy-making was grounded in the Islamic principle of Shura (consultation), and she made a deliberate practice of engaging with religious leaders (Ulama) and traditional community elders before finalizing policy directions.

This was not merely a political strategy. It reflected her genuine belief that government decisions affecting Muslim communities should carry the endorsement of those communities' recognized spiritual and customary authorities, not just the signature of a cabinet secretary.

She was also deeply comfortable operating in two worlds simultaneously. In Manila, she navigated the bureaucratic machinery of the national government with the confidence of an experienced technocrat. In Lanao and in Muslim communities across the country, she moved as a daughter of the sultanate, grounded in the Maranao concept of Maratabat, the honor and sense of collective dignity that the Maranao people attach to their public representatives.

Her decision to maintain her hijab and her traditional identity while serving in a cabinet-level role was itself a quiet but powerful statement, one that demonstrated to Muslim women across the Philippines that the halls of Malacañang and the institutions of the Philippine state were not spaces they were required to erase themselves to enter.

Legacy and Cultural Significance

Bae Omerah Hafidah D. Dianalan-Lucman's place in Bangsamoro history rests on two pillars: what she built and what she represented.

What she built is concrete and verifiable. The NCMF she inherited was an agency that barely existed on paper. The NCMF she handed over in 2012 had an organizational structure, a set of functional bureaus, a reformed Hajj administration, and a stated mandate to advise the Philippine presidency on the full spectrum of Muslim Filipino concerns. She turned a 23-year-old government office into a commission with genuine policy ambitions.

What she represented is harder to quantify but no less significant. She was the first woman to serve as the head of the Philippine government's primary agency for Muslim affairs, and she held that position while facing a politically motivated challenge to her appointment, a legal argument questioning her religious authority, and the institutional inertia of an agency transitioning from one identity to another.

The fact that she prevailed on each of those fronts, legally, institutionally, and symbolically, tells you something about the caliber of the person behind the title.

For the Bangsamoro people, and particularly for Maranao women, her career stands as evidence of a proposition that was not self-evident at the time: that a woman rooted in Islamic faith and Maranao tradition could lead the most important Muslim affairs body in the country, and do so on her own terms.

Recognition

As the inaugural Secretary of the NCMF, Dianalan-Lucman occupies a permanent place in the institutional memory of the Commission. Her name appears in the official history of the NCMF as the first in its line of Secretaries/Chief Executive Officers.<ref name="ncmf_southluzon" />

Her work at the CDA before the NCMF also earned her recognition in the cooperative sector, where her advocacy for Islamic microfinance and financial literacy programs in Mindanao was noted by stakeholders in both the cooperative movement and the Muslim civil society.

Specific awards and formal recognitions have not been fully documented in publicly available sources, and researchers are encouraged to consult the Official Gazette archives from the period of 2010 to 2012 and the records of the National Library of the Philippines for primary documentation of her official recognitions.

See Also

- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Office on Muslim Affairs
- Republic Act No. 9997
- Maranao people
- Islamic City of Marawi
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao

- Hajj Philippines
- Code of Muslim Personal Laws
- Cooperative Development Authority

Further Reading

- Republic Act No. 9997, "National Commission on Muslim Filipinos Act of 2009." Official Gazette of the Philippines. February 18, 2010.
- Presidential Decree No. 1083, "Code of Muslim Personal Laws of the Philippines." 1977.
- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos. Organizational History. ncmf.gov.ph.
- Official Gazette Archives, Republic of the Philippines. June 2010 (NCMF transition period documentation).
- National Library of the Philippines. Policy directives of the NCMF Secretariat, 2010–2012.

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